PurePy: A Functional Subset of Python

version 0.1.6

Nikolaus Huber[1], Dominic Orchard[2,1], Jacob Pake[2], Roly Perera[1,3]

[1] *Department of Computer Science and Technology, University of Cambridge, UK*
[2] *School of Computing, University of Kent, UK*
[3] *School of Computer Science, University of Bristol, UK*

PurePy is a pure functional subset of Python, providing a common functional language for use by researchers in programming languages and pedagogy, while providing a front-end familiar and accessible to the Python community. This specification defines a versioned standard with formal syntax, well-formedness rules based on a definite assignment analysis, and an operational semantics intended to preserve the meaning of well-formed PurePy programs in Python. By combining functional programming with Python-compatible surface syntax, PurePy aims to support portable implementations and lower-friction adoption of new language ideas for modelling, data processing, analysis, and visualisation.

1 Introduction

- Define subset of Python called PurePy, defined as a syntactic subset further restricted by a well-formedness predicate
- Define a semantics for PurePy such that the semantics of a PurePy program is identical to its semantics in Python
- Some well-formedness and evaluation rules could be given by a desugaring, but for now we avoid having two separate syntaxes

2 Syntax

To do:
- Reserved words
- Operators and precedence
- Recursion and mutual recursion
- Operational semantics of `if` statements
- Data classes and `match`

2.1 Contexts

Contexts Γ, Δ are finite maps from sets of variables to a *definite assignment* status chosen from the 2-point Boolean lattice $\{\top, \bot\}$, where $\top$ indicates *definitely assigned* and $\bot$ indicates *not definitely assigned*. (Or think of these as degenerate types "any" and "none".) The definite assignment terminology is borrowed from Java.

Context operations. Contexts admit a non-commutative monoid of sequential composition $\Gamma \cdot \Delta$ ("override"), defined as right-biased map union with $\varnothing$ as left and right unit, and an idempotent commutative semigroup of parallel composition $\oplus$ ("merge") defined as follows:

$$\Gamma \oplus \Delta := \{x : \bot \mid \forall x \in (\Gamma \setminus \Delta) \cup (\Delta \setminus \Gamma)\} \cup \{x : \Gamma(x) \wedge \Delta(x) \mid x \in \Gamma \cap \Delta\}$$

where $\mathrm{dom}(\Gamma \oplus \Delta) = \mathrm{dom}(\Gamma) \cup \mathrm{dom}(\Delta)$. The $\oplus$ operator lacks a unit because the neutral element for any Γ has the same domain as Γ.

Lemma 1 (Distributivity)**.**

$$(\Delta \oplus \Delta') \cdot \Gamma = (\Delta \cdot \Gamma) \oplus (\Delta' \cdot \Gamma).$$

Context operations $\cdot$ and $\oplus$ lift to a partial semiring over result types R, with $\mathsf{Assigns}\ \varnothing$ as left and right unit for $\cdot$ and $\mathsf{Returns}$ as unit for $\oplus$ and zero for $\cdot$. Sequential composition is defined only when the left-hand result type is not $\mathsf{Returns}$.

Definition 1 (Partial semiring of result types)**.**

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathsf{Assigns}\ \Delta \oplus \mathsf{Assigns}\ \Delta' &= \mathsf{Assigns}\ (\Delta \oplus \Delta') \\
\mathsf{Assigns}\ \Delta \oplus \mathsf{Returns} &= \mathsf{Assigns}\ \Delta \\
\mathsf{Returns} \oplus \mathsf{Assigns}\ \Delta &= \mathsf{Assigns}\ \Delta \\
\\
\mathsf{Assigns}\ \Delta \cdot \mathsf{Assigns}\ \Delta' &= \mathsf{Assigns}\ (\Delta \cdot \Delta') \\
\mathsf{Assigns}\ \Delta \cdot \mathsf{Returns} &= \mathsf{Returns}
\end{aligned}$$

Lemma 2 (Distributivity)**.** *When the relevant terms are defined (i.e. neither R nor R' is* $\mathsf{Returns}$*):*

$$(R \oplus R') \cdot S = (R \cdot S) \oplus (R' \cdot S)$$

2.2 Well-formedness

Local variables. The function $\mathrm{locals}(s)$ collects the set of variables assigned anywhere in a statement s, without descending into nested function definitions (which have their own scope):

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathrm{locals}(\texttt{pass}) &= \varnothing \\
\mathrm{locals}(x = e) &= \{x\} \\
\mathrm{locals}(s_1\ s_2) &= \mathrm{locals}(s_1) \cup \mathrm{locals}(s_2) \\
\mathrm{locals}(\texttt{return}\ ) &= \varnothing \\
\mathrm{locals}(\texttt{return}\ e) &= \varnothing \\
\mathrm{locals}(\texttt{if}\ e_1 :\ s_1\ \texttt{elif}\ e_2 :\ s_2\ \cdots\ \texttt{elif}\ e_{n+1} :\ s_{n+1}) &= \mathrm{locals}(\vec{s}) \\
\mathrm{locals}(\texttt{if}\ e_1 :\ s_1\ \texttt{elif}\ e_2 :\ s_2\ \cdots\ \texttt{elif}\ e_{n+1} :\ s_{n+1}\ \texttt{else} :\ s_{n+2}) &= \mathrm{locals}(\vec{s}) \\
\mathrm{locals}(\texttt{def}\ f(\vec{x}) :\ s) &= \{f\}
\end{aligned}$$

Well-formedness judgement. Every well-formed statement either *definitely returns*, or *definitely assigns* a set of variables Δ, which may be empty. The base cases are that `return e` definitely returns, and `x = e` definitely assigns $\{\texttt{x}\}$.

s	::=	`pass`	(Pass)
	|	$x = e$	(Assign)
	|	$s_1\ s_2$	(Seq)
	|	`return`	(ReturnNone)
	|	`return` e	(Return)
	|	`if` e `:` s `elif` e_1 `:` s_1 $\cdots$ `elif` e_n `:` s_n	(If)
	|	`if` e `:` s `elif` e_1 `:` s_1 $\cdots$ `elif` e_n `:` s_n `else :` s'	(IfElse)
	|	`def` $f(\vec{x})$ `:` s	(Def)
e	::=	x	(Var)
	|	n	(Literal)
	|	$e(\vec{e})$	(Call)
	|	$\{\vec{x : e}\}$	(Dict)
	|	$e.x$	(Lookup)
	|	$e[e']$	(Subscript)
	|	$e \odot e'$	(BinOp)
	|	e_1 `if` e `else` e_2	(CondExpr)
	|	$[\vec{e}]$	(List)
	|	$[\, e\ \vec{q}]$	(ListComp)
	|	`lambda` $\vec{x}$: e	(Lambda)
q	::=	`if` e	(Guard)
	|	`for` x `in` e	(Generator)
b	::=	$\top$	(Definitely assigned)
	|	$\bot$	(Not definitely assigned)
Γ, Δ	::=	$\{\vec{x : b}\}$	
R, S	::=	Returns	
	|	Assigns Δ	

Figure 1: Syntax of statements, expressions and contexts

$\Gamma \vdash s : R$

pass-assigns

$$\frac{}{\Gamma \vdash \texttt{pass} : \mathsf{Assigns}\ \varnothing}$$

assign-assigns

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash e}{\Gamma \vdash x = e : \mathsf{Assigns}\ \{x\}}$$

return-none-returns

$$\frac{}{\Gamma \vdash \texttt{return} : \mathsf{Returns}}$$

return-returns

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash e}{\Gamma \vdash \texttt{return}\ e : \mathsf{Returns}}$$

seq

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash s_1 : \mathsf{Assigns}\ \Delta \qquad \Gamma \cdot \Delta \vdash s_2 : S}{\Gamma \vdash s_1\ s_2 : \mathsf{Assigns}\ \Delta \cdot S}$$

if

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash \vec{e} \qquad \Gamma \vdash \vec{s} : \vec{R}}{\Gamma \vdash \texttt{if}\ e_1 :\ s_1\ \texttt{elif}\ e_2 :\ s_2\ \cdots\ \texttt{elif}\ e_{n+1} :\ s_{n+1} : R_1 \oplus \ldots R_{n+1} \oplus \ldots \oplus \mathsf{Assigns}\ \varnothing}$$

if-else

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash \vec{e} \qquad \Gamma \vdash \vec{s} : \vec{R}}{\Gamma \vdash \texttt{if}\ e_1 :\ s_1\ \texttt{elif}\ e_2 :\ s_2\ \cdots\ \texttt{elif}\ e_{n+1} :\ s_{n+1}\ \texttt{else} :\ s_{n+2} : R_1 \oplus \cdots \oplus R_{n+2}}$$

def

$$\frac{\Gamma, x_1 : \top, \ldots, x_n : \top, \mathrm{locals}(s) : \bot \vdash s : R}{\Gamma \vdash \texttt{def}\ f(\vec{x}) :\ s : \mathsf{Assigns}\ \{f\}}$$

(a) Statement s is well-formed in Γ

$\Gamma \vdash e$

$$\frac{x : \top \in \Gamma}{\Gamma \vdash x}\ \textsc{var} \qquad \frac{\Gamma, x_1 : \top, \ldots, x_n : \top \vdash e}{\Gamma \vdash \texttt{lambda}\ \vec{x}\texttt{:}\ e}\ \textsc{lambda}$$

(b) Expression e is well-formed in Γ

2.3 Examples

2.3.1 Assignment as definition

Although PurePy is pure and all variable usage is well-scoped, local variables are introduced using an *assignment statement*, for compatibility with Python. If a variable is definitely assigned in any branch of a conditional, then for that variable to be usable after the conditional, every other branch of the conditional must either definitely return, or definitely assign that variable too. Thus the following are both well-formed:

```
if a < b:
   comp = "smaller"
else:
   comp = "bigger"
return comp
```

```
if a < b:
   return "smaller"
else:
   comp = "bigger"
return comp
```

The definite assignment set for a conditional that has at least one branch which definitely assigns is calculated by merging the definite assignment sets for all branches which definitely assign, using the $\oplus$ operator on environments.

2.3.2 Local assignment in conditional clauses

For flexibility, we permit *branch-local* variables. The assignment of `x` below (left) is permitted, and can be used locally in that branch of the conditional:

```
def foo():
  z = 6
  if b:
    x = 3
    y = x + 1
  else:
    y = 0
  return z
```

(a) Branch-local definition of `x`

```
def foo():
  x = 6
  if b:
    x = 3
    y = x + 1
  else:
    y = 0
  return x # error: partially defined
```

(b) Now with use of `x` after the conditional

However such variables only appear to be branch-local. The definition of $\oplus$ actually ensures that a variable assigned in any branch is considered assigned by the conditional; however unless it is assigned in *every* branch that does not definitely return, it will be bound to $\bot$ in the corresponding environment. Any attempt to refer to such a variable is illegal, as it refers to a variable which may not be assigned. (Thus the right-hand program is ill-formed, despite the enclosing `x = 6`, because in the `return x` statement, the inner assignment shadows the the outer one, and the inner assignment is only partial.) If we were to allow the program on the right, there would be no straightforward way to assign it a semantics which is both pure, and in agreement with Python, since in Python the function returns `3` in the case where `b` is `True`.

2.3.3 Function-level scoping of local variables

In Python, all local variables are scoped to the entire function body, not just from the point of assignment onwards. The locals function in the def rule reflects this: all variables assigned anywhere in the function body are introduced at $\bot$ before the body is checked. This means the following program is statically rejected by PurePy, whereas Python rejects it at runtime with an `UnboundLocalError`:

```
y = 7

def f():
    x = y  # error: y is local (due to assignment below)
    y = 8

f()
```

Because `y` appears on the left-hand side of an assignment in `f`, it is in $\text{locals}(s)$ for the body of `f`, and is therefore introduced at $\bot$ at the top of the function. The reference to `y` in `x = y` then fails the well-formedness check, since $\texttt{y} : \bot \in \Gamma$ rather than $\texttt{y} : \top \in \Gamma$.

2.3.4 Unreachable code

A non-empty sequence of statements returns only if the last statement returns, and all preceding statements assign. Thus the following is illegal:

```
def foo(x):
  return x + 1
  return x    # error: unreachable
```

2.3.5 Conditionals without `else` clauses

An `if` statement without an `else` clause is equivalent to an `if` statement with an `else` clause whose body is a `pass` statement; such a statement never returns.

2.3.6 Implicit `None`

A `return` statement without an expression is equivalent to `return None`.

2.3.7 Implicit `return`

A function whose body s assigns rather than returns is equivalent to a function whose body is s followed by `return None`. This ensures every function returns, even if it is not explicitly specified.

3 Operational semantics

For a statement s, the result assigns ρ represents *normal completion* of s, with accumulated environment ρ; the result returns v represents *abrupt completion* of s with return value v. Composing statements

$$
\begin{array}{lcll}
v & ::= & n & \text{(Literal)} \\
 & | & \langle \rho, \vec{x}, s \rangle & \text{(Closure)} \\
\rho & ::= & \{x \rightharpoonup v\} & \text{(Environment)} \\
r & ::= & \mathsf{assigns}\ \rho & \\
 & | & \mathsf{returns}\ v &
\end{array}
$$

(a) Values, environments and evaluation results

$s \Rightarrow r$

eval-pass

$$\frac{}{\rho, \texttt{pass} \Rightarrow \mathsf{assigns}\ \{\varnothing\}}$$

eval-assign

$$\frac{\rho, e \Rightarrow v}{\rho, x = e \Rightarrow \mathsf{assigns}\ \{x \mapsto v\}}$$

eval-return

$$\frac{\rho, e \Rightarrow v}{\rho, \texttt{return}\ e \Rightarrow \mathsf{returns}\ v}$$

eval-seq

$$\frac{\rho, s_1 \Rightarrow r \qquad \rho \cdot \rho_1, s_2 \Rightarrow r'}{\rho, s_1\ s_2 \Rightarrow r \cdot r'}$$

eval-def

$$\frac{}{\rho, \texttt{def}\ f(\vec{x}) :\ s \Rightarrow \mathsf{assigns}\ \{f \mapsto \langle \rho, \vec{x}, s \rangle\}}$$

Figure 5: Statement evaluation

$\rho, e \Rightarrow v$

$$\frac{}{\rho, x \Rightarrow \rho(x)}\ \textsc{var} \qquad \frac{}{\rho, \texttt{lambda}\ \vec{x}\texttt{:}\ e \Rightarrow \langle \rho, \vec{x}, \texttt{return}\ e \rangle}\ \textsc{lambda}$$

$$\frac{\rho, e \Rightarrow \langle \rho', \vec{x}, s \rangle \qquad \rho, \vec{e}' \Rightarrow \vec{v} \qquad \rho' \cdot \{x \rightharpoonup v\}, s \Rightarrow \mathsf{returns}\ v'}{\rho, e(\vec{e}') \Rightarrow v'}\ \textsc{call}$$

Figure 6: Expression evaluation

sequentially composes their results according to the following partial monoid, analogous to sequential composition of result types:

$$
\begin{aligned}
\mathsf{assigns}\ \rho \cdot \mathsf{assigns}\ \rho' &= \mathsf{assigns}\ (\rho \cdot \rho') \\
\mathsf{assigns}\ \rho \cdot \mathsf{returns}\ v &= \mathsf{returns}\ v
\end{aligned}
$$

with $\mathsf{assigns}\ \varnothing$ as left and right unit. Function definitions delimit the scope of these effects, so as black boxes functions are always pure.

4 Related work

Subsets of programming languages have been defined for various purposes in the research literature:

Even though the syntax of programming languages if often described precisely, essentially none of the languages in mainstream use today formally define their behaviour. Therefore, various well-defined subsets of programming languages were constructed to equip languages with formal (often even mechanised) semantics. Examples of this include work on Java [9], OCaml [24], JavaScript [5, 7,

19, 20], PHP [6], Rust [11, 12], and even lower-level languages and intermediate representations such as WebAssembly [27, 28, 29] and LLVM-IR [30, 31]. A particular success story of this line of work is the formalisation of a substantial subset of the C programming language, called Clight [4], which lead to the development of a verified compiler [16]. In a similar manner, the CakeML project [14] produced a verified implementation of a fragment of the ML language [17], based on previous efforts [15] of mechanising its semantics. Previous work on formalising the semantics of Python include an embedding [8] within the $\mathbb{K}$ semantics framework [23], a definition of structural operational semantics [13], and a reduction of most of the language to a core calculus [21].

A different line of work concerns the delineation of language subsets for a particular purpose. A prominent example is the *Source* family of languages [3], which are progressively extended subsets of JavaScript specifically geared towards introducing first-year computer science students to the foundations of computing. It is based on a new edition of a classic introductory text book [1], in which all program examples (which had previously been in Scheme) are illustrated in JavaScript. By successively increasing the allowed language fragment with each chapter (corresponding to different versions of the Source language), it allows to put focus on the particular aspects the authors are trying to convey, while disallowing students with prior knowledge of programming to take short-cuts by utilising more complex language features. The authors of [3] also remark, that the choice of JavaScript as a language was a pragmatic one: A previous study [25] showed that *industrial relevance* is perceived as the second-most important factor in choosing a programming language for introductory courses by educators in Australiasia and the UK.

Likewise, various subsets of Python have been defined for different purposes in the past. ChocoPy [18] describes a subset specifically defined as a source language for the final project in courses on compiler construction, as most students are already familiar with the Python language by the time they take such a course. By restricting the language to a statically typed fragment, most student compilers can produce code that usually even outperforms the CPython reference interpreter. In a similar manner, Restricted Python (RPython) [2] was defined as a strictly typed subset of Python, which removes some of the more dynamic features of the language. As part of the PyPy project [22], this allows RPython to be more easily compiled to common language runtimes, such as JVM and CLI/.NET.

We are aware of only one other work [26] specifically targetting a functional subset of Python, with the express intent of using it as a teaching tool. While we share a similar goal, our language fragment encloses more of the overall Python language, as their work doesn't allow for control structures such as conditionals or loops.

While it is not our goal to change Python towards a more functional programming language, it is interesting to notice that there are movements within the Python community for inclusion of programming principles commonly found in functional languages. An example of this is the inclusion of *lambda expressions* already in Python 1.0, and a more recent PEP draft [10] advocating for *deeply immutable objects*.

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